

Announcer [00:00:04–00:00:37]

Welcome to The Lighter Side of the Spectrum, the podcast that celebrates the multiple hats we wear and the juggling acts we perform in life. Whether you're parenting kids and teens on the autism spectrum, navigating the ever-evolving healthcare industry, or building a more inclusive and impactful world, this is your space to find connection, inspiration, and growth. Together, we'll share stories, tackle challenges, and explore how innovation and inclusion create better outcomes for everyone. Because no matter the spectrum, there's always a lighter side. Now here's your host, David Kaufer.

David Kaufer [00:00:37–00:02:30]

Hello again, everybody, and welcome back to Lighter Side of the Spectrum. I'm David Kaufer. Today we're talking about something I think deserves far more attention than it gets. When most people think about autism, they think about communication differences, sensory challenges, repetitive behaviors, or social interaction. But what they don't think about usually is trauma.

Not because trauma is necessarily a part of autism itself, but because so many autistic children and adults experience repeated events that leave lasting emotional wounds. School struggles, bullying, hospitalizations, family disruption, being misunderstood, not being able to communicate, living in a world that often wasn't designed with them in mind. Those experiences change people, and today's guest understands that reality as well as anyone. Stephen Laine is a father, autism advocate, and writer whose honest Facebook posts have resonated with thousands of families, including my own.

Over the past several months, his family has faced every parent's nightmare, including psychiatric hospitalization, repeated elopement, navigating a system that often seems unprepared to help. But through it all, Stephen has continued to share something that's incredibly rare— not polished success stories, But real life, the actual fear, the exhaustion, and the hope, and ultimately what healing can look like. Stephen, welcome to The Lighter Side of the Spectrum.

Stephen Laine [00:02:30–00:02:31]

Thank you for having me.

David Kaufer [00:02:31–00:03:05]

Yeah, I'm really happy to have you here. I'm glad that our paths have crossed. Like I said, one of the things that struck me is just, uh, your raw honesty, uh, in terms of approaching this. You don't always see this. in our space in terms of other parents who post on Facebook and other platforms. One of the things you wrote that really grabbed my attention was this. You said, I didn't choose advocacy, advocacy chose me.

Yeah.

So I think every parent probably listening to this right now understands exactly what you meant, but I'd like you to talk about what it means to you and tell us about your journey?

Stephen Laine [00:03:17–00:03:41]

Well, okay. Um, so I will, um, kind of go back in time a little bit here. So yeah, please, we'll go. Yeah, so we're gonna go back to the start of when I went into the autism world, as you could say. And that was in 2011. Um, I was living in Oxford, Michigan. And for those of your listeners who don't know where Oxford is, that's about 40 miles north of Detroit.

Okay.

It's a semi-rural area. So anyways, we're noticing, my wife at the time, we were both noticing, I'm divorced right now and I'll get into that later.

David Kaufer [00:03:55–00:03:59]

Yeah, but we definitely want to get into that. I know that's a big part of your story too.

Stephen Laine [00:03:59–00:04:26]

It is part of my story too, but I'll get into that later. So anyways, in 2011, a lot of people were going to me and my wife at the time, They were noticing certain things with Matthew, like he wasn't hitting certain milestones. He wasn't walking at the appropriate age. He wasn't communicating at all. He was just communicating with hums, as I would like to say. And he was about 3 and a half to 4 years old at

the time.

David Kaufer [00:04:26–00:04:27]

Okay.

Stephen Laine [00:04:27–00:04:53]

And so, you know, everyone thinks, you know, there's something going on with him. Is it hearing impairment? Is it something else? So one of the first things I do, I get his hearing tested. Came back. Yep, he came back normal. So it wasn't that. So then I enrolled him into preschool through our school district. And they're thinking autism. And I'm disagreeing with them.

David Kaufer [00:04:53–00:04:56]

I was gonna say, were you thinking autism at all?

Stephen Laine [00:04:56–00:05:25]

No, I wasn't. No, I wasn't. No, I wasn't. And so I'm disagreeing with them. And so I'm like, well, I'm gonna go find some doctors, and I'm gonna see if I can get him, you know, see what they say. Well, I got 2 opinions, 2 different opinions. And it was the same thing, autism. And so I'm like, well, this is a done deal. And I still wasn't able to come to terms with it.

David Kaufer [00:05:25–00:05:26]

And that's fine.

Stephen Laine [00:05:26–00:05:31]

Now, I got a younger son by the name of Aiden. At the time, he was 2 and a half.

David Kaufer [00:05:32–00:05:33]

Okay.

Stephen Laine [00:05:33–00:05:57]

And I rolled him into preschool. And I remember taking him to preschool first day. And he's not communicating with any of the peers there. He's just stacking blocks upon blocks upon blocks, perfect alignment, and humming to the blocks. Now, at this point, I already did a little bit of homework and knew what the signs are for autism at this point.

Stephen Laine [00:05:58–00:06:37]

Right. And I'm like, oh, here we go again. So I guess he's gotta get diagnosed. And so I got him diagnosed, you know, at the same time, went through the same process, went to a natural doctor, got him diagnosed. So he was diagnosed. So, and at the time, once Aiden's diagnosis came through, I started looking at ABA services. Well, at the time in Michigan, ABA wasn't covered under insurance. So, and it was— there wasn't all these ABA centers around like there is today. So I inquired about it. And they said, well, it's gonna cost you about \$30,000 a year out of pocket.

Stephen Laine [00:06:38–00:06:50]

So that's crazy. And like I said, at the time, insurances in Michigan didn't cover it. So we're like, well, this is beyond my own— my means, you know, I don't have I don't have \$30 grand.

David Kaufer [00:06:50–00:06:51]

\$30 grand sitting around to—

Stephen Laine [00:06:51–00:07:30]

Sit around just to fork over for 1 year of ABA services. So I took what I could get as far as therapies, what I could find at the time. And so we did that for quite a few years. And then probably fast forward to 2019, my wife and I were having a lot of serious issues at that point and we got divorced. Eventually got divorced. I'll get into that. But we separated in September of 2019. The boys switched schools from Oxford to where they're presently at right now.

Okay.

And so I'm not like near Oxford or anything. I'm more closer. I'm in like suburban Detroit right now. So that was a big transition for the boys. And they were really traumatized from it because again, they're autistic and they can only understand certain concepts.

Many children don't understand the concept of divorce, but when you put that on an autistic child, Mm-

hmm. the trauma's gonna be there. And that kind of goes towards, like I was saying in a lot of my posts, where autism care and trauma do go hand in hand. You know, they were wondering why we weren't together anymore. They were wondering why we had 2 separate homes. which it was like at the time, we were in 2 separate homes, you know, they were living in one home part of the time, they were living at my, at their mother's place.

David Kaufer [00:08:21–00:08:44]

So I just want, I just want a quick question here, Steve. And that is, so it sounds like both boys, again, they were diagnosed, but sounds like they were able to gain some functionality to communicate, like, so they've been, they've been able to speak to a certain degree. Would you say they have limited vocabulary or, you know, communication skills? Or, you know, because it sounds like they didn't, that they were You said they were confused about the living situation, which is understandable.

Stephen Laine [00:08:44–00:08:46]

Yeah, I'm sorry, fast forward to that.

David Kaufer [00:08:46–00:08:47]

But yeah, no, it's okay.

Stephen Laine [00:08:47–00:09:15]

Yeah. But back to when they were in elementary school, I want to say by the time they hit kindergarten, they were starting to get somewhat verbal. Now, my youngest son, Aiden, was more verbal at a younger age than Matthew was. Matthew didn't start becoming verbal till about 5 years old. So that's around the time he started saying his first words. Um, eventually we were able to get into very basic conversations with both of them.

David Kaufer [00:09:15–00:09:16]

Okay. Okay.

Stephen Laine [00:09:16–00:09:18]

Yeah. So, okay.

David Kaufer [00:09:18–00:09:46]

So please continue. So, so that's the background. So, you know, again, in 2019, it's gotta be so hard. I mean, again, your relationships are challenging. I mean, that's a, that's a whole nother conversation I can have with so many people talking about balancing and managing Marriages, relationships when you're dealing with one, let alone 2 autistic kids. So you guys, you know, going through these challenges and you're trying to manage the trauma of changing school districts.

Stephen Laine [00:09:46–00:10:28]

Yeah. Yeah. So we went through that. So that's in September 2019. And my youngest son, Aiden, was having meltdowns at school just because he was unable to cope with the changes at the time. He wanted to go back to his old school, didn't want to go to where he was presently going. Matthew was also still having some issues. He wasn't having any meltdowns, but he was acting very hyper in the classroom and he wasn't even focusing. So let's fast forward to 3 months later. Yeah, probably maybe not 3 months, maybe more like 4 to 5 months later, COVID happens.

David Kaufer [00:10:28–00:10:34]

Right, right, right. Yeah. Because you're going— yeah, we're going from 2019, obviously, into early 2020. Yeah, COVID hits. Good times.

Stephen Laine [00:10:34–00:10:43]

COVID hits. So we're all in lockdown. You know, we can't go anywhere, kids can't go to school, we're going to— they're going to Zoom, they're going to school over Zoom. Yeah.

And, you know, they're wondering what's going on here. And so I ended up getting in touch with a therapist for both my boys, because all the stuff they've been through at that point. Well, again, during the lockdown sessions, they're over Zoom.

David Kaufer [00:11:00–00:11:01]

Yeah.

Stephen Laine [00:11:01–00:11:09]

You try to do therapy with an autistic child over Zoom. For some, it might work. I don't think it really worked for my boys, really, to be honest with you.

David Kaufer [00:11:09–00:11:11]

Yeah, it's hard. It's a challenge for sure.

Stephen Laine [00:11:11–00:11:46]

It is. It was. And so eventually, you know, lockdowns, you know, we eased back into the public school setting once things are opening up. My youngest son, my— both my sons at this point were going to middle school. And so I actually, which was really fortunate because by this point COVID happened, they had a break from everything, from being on lockdown, which is ironic as it sounds. I was actually kind of grateful for that, you know, everything they've been through.

David Kaufer [00:11:46–00:11:49]

Right, right. Kind of paused everything in a way.

Stephen Laine [00:11:49–00:11:51]

Exactly. Yes, it did.

Yeah.

And so once they were able to go back to you know, an actual school setting, they started thriving, both of them. And they were both in middle school at that point. So let's fast forward a little bit. So now we're back in the school setting. So 2021 hits. And so at that point, and which I'm going to get in a little bit of detail, but I can't go fully detailed because it's kind of personal, a little too personal.

David Kaufer [00:12:17–00:12:18]

Yeah, yeah, I understand.

Stephen Laine [00:12:19–00:12:39]

I ended up taking over for both my boys to where they were here with me full-time, 24/7. And this happened in October of 2021. Again, this was another transition. They want to know why they were no longer living with their mother. They wanted to know what happened.

Oh yeah.

They lost all their stuff, all their belongings. So I had to replace everything that they owned that they had at her house.

Oh, wow.

Yeah. So, and this, this was very traumatic for them. And, you know, they were— there was some regression when they were in school with both boys. But I want to say after probably about 3 to 6 months, we did get through that. And, you know, they were able to move on successfully.

David Kaufer [00:13:05–00:13:28]

And so every day you're— I mean, you're— this is something that you still had to manage. I mean, it's kind of funny, kind of Kind of gloss over it like, oh, 3 to 6 months, you know, they kind of got over it. But in the meantime, you're still trying to manage their lives and doing this on your own. I mean, you're essentially a single dad, I assume, working full-time and, and dealing with them.

Stephen Laine [00:13:28–00:13:31]

I do, but I also get a lot of help from my mother.

David Kaufer [00:13:31–00:13:32]

Okay.

Stephen Laine [00:13:32–00:13:35]

And she helps me out with the boys. So when I'm at work, she's watching them.

David Kaufer [00:13:35–00:13:38]

Yeah. Yeah. That's great to have that support. Okay.

Stephen Laine [00:13:38–00:13:42]

Yeah. Because there'd be no way I could work full-time without her help. There'd be no way.

David Kaufer [00:13:42–00:13:53]

Right, right. Exactly. Exactly. I think that's one of the things, you know, most, again, most people listening can relate to all too well. I mean, we need that support.

Stephen Laine [00:13:53–00:13:56]

Happy.

David Kaufer [00:13:56–00:14:01]

My son Stone likes to pop in every so often. So he just gave us one of those happies.

Stephen Laine [00:14:01–00:14:22]

Cute. So anyway, so You know, and I think that's kind of what led me to this pathway of advocacy, because I know it's all on me. You know, it's all on me. And, you know, if I don't do my part to make my children's lives better, then who will?

David Kaufer [00:14:22–00:14:36]

Exactly. Yeah. I mean, it's on us. I mean, you're the guy, you're the man in that situation. So what did advocacy Look like early on for you? And, you know, was it— tell me about that.

Stephen Laine [00:14:36–00:15:02]

Well, early on it was, you know, kind of more or less like— I want to say like early on, I don't want to say— it probably started where I really got involved with it is when I became a full-time parent, you know, where I was just taking the boys on my own. That's when I said, you know, I got to really step it up here, you know, and not that I wasn't, But at that point, it was like, okay, we got to take things to the next level here.

David Kaufer [00:15:02–00:15:10]

Yeah. It sounds like something kind of clicked in the way that you're like, oh boy, like you said, I've got to take this to a new level.

Stephen Laine [00:15:10–00:15:55]

Yeah. And there's been times where I had to fight for certain things in their school for services and things I thought that they would thrive in for both Matthew and Aiden. Unfortunately, I haven't had to do that a whole lot because I got a really good relationship with their schools. But there's been times I've had to say, hey, this method might not be working. Let's try this.

And sometimes you got to get administration involved. I had to do that a few times. So that's where I've had to do some of the advocacy work. For me, it's been more like, I think probably where I'm strongest in, I'm not trying to give myself an ego boost here, is—

Announcer [00:15:55–00:15:56]

Sure.

Stephen Laine [00:15:56–00:15:57]

I think it's in my writing.

David Kaufer [00:15:57–00:16:03]

Absolutely. I'll concur with that, Steve. Yeah. Yeah.

Stephen Laine [00:16:04–00:16:12]

And so, you know, I've been actually writing on Facebook a lot since 2012. Actually, 2012 is when I started writing.

David Kaufer [00:16:12–00:16:13]

Oh, okay. Wow.

Stephen Laine [00:16:14–00:16:47]

Yeah. But I really kind of stepped it up in the last couple of months. You know, once, you know, Aiden — once Matthew was hospitalized. Which we'll get into. That's when I'm like, let's take it up another notch here. That was kind of like another point for me in my life where I'm like, I'm seeing a lot of things I'm not liking. And he's 19 years old now and a lot of the things they once had as far as services that were there at one time are no longer there. Right. Yeah.

David Kaufer [00:16:47–00:17:13]

Right. Yeah. I mean, that's a big transition as well and something We've talked about here in terms of when those school services go away, some of these other, you know, all the support that's provided, what limited support in some cases there may be for kids on the spectrum and parents goes away when they, you know, when they get older. I mean, it's not like, you know, these are, yes, these are people who don't go away. I mean, they still need support.

Stephen Laine [00:17:13–00:17:26]

They do. They do. Because I mean, like my son Matthew, he's 19 years old, but mentally he's not at a typical 19-year-old level. Yeah. I mean, he's much younger.

David Kaufer [00:17:26–00:17:42]

Yeah. He needs— it sounds like he just has a lot of support needs, you know, that maybe other, you know, other 19-year-olds who aren't in the same situation need in terms of being independent or sufficient in different ways.

Stephen Laine [00:17:42–00:17:52]

Yeah. Matthew needs 24/7 supervision. He's very I'm not trying to talk down on him, but I'm just mentioning the challenges that we have with him.

David Kaufer [00:17:52–00:17:53]

Yeah, please.

Stephen Laine [00:17:53–00:18:10]

He's very impulsive. Like, I could tell him, no, like this morning before we went on, I'm saying, Matthew, do not go into the fridge and grab the pop. Do not go in the fridge and grab the pop. What does he do? Goes in the fridge and grabs the pop first thing in the morning. I'm like, you're not supposed to be drinking pop first thing in the morning.

David Kaufer [00:18:11–00:18:28]

Yeah. You know, he's a 19-year-old. I mean, that's kind of funny. I mean, I laugh only because, again, like I said, I think there There are a lot of parents that can relate to that, Steve. You know, there's a lot of college students out there drinking Mountain Dew. But yeah, but that's a good example.

Stephen Laine [00:18:28–00:18:44]

Right. Yeah. But you know, it's the impulsiveness with Matthew. That's been one of his biggest challenges. And that's how, that's how we got into our crisis that you, you know, with the hospitalization, which I didn't mention on Facebook quite a bit.

David Kaufer [00:18:44–00:18:53]

Oh yeah, that was a big, that was a big event. Can we just Talk about that, because I think that's obviously a pivotal moment in so many ways.

Stephen Laine [00:18:53–00:19:16]

Oh, yeah. Oh, yeah. I mean, it was pretty much, you know, a life-changing experience for me. So I'll go back to 2012. While I was at work, he did elope one time. And he was found like 15 minutes later and returned back home. We didn't have an elopement incident since. Oh, okay.

David Kaufer [00:19:17–00:19:20]

So you, I mean, so this was like a, you know, a one and done thing as far as—

Stephen Laine [00:19:20–00:19:46]

Yeah, it was kind of like a one and done thing. Yeah. Yeah. So anyways, I'm at work. I get a phone call from my mom saying Matthew ran away. So I leave work, I come home and we're looking for him. We can't find him. And you know, At the point, you know, I didn't have a GPS on him at that point or anything like that. Because I think, you know, we haven't had this issue for so many years.

David Kaufer [00:19:46–00:19:47]

Yeah, right.

Stephen Laine [00:19:48–00:20:03]

So anyways, we're looking for him all along my street. And one of my neighbors goes, he's in here, he's in my house. So he got himself so worked up looking for DVDs and video games that he went into

someone else's house.

David Kaufer [00:20:03–00:20:05]

And for them—

Stephen Laine [00:20:05–00:20:25]

Looking for him. Yeah. He's in the basement. I go in the basement, you know, trying to get him out of there. He's a big guy now. He's like, he, he's about 5'9, 5'10, and he weighs about 220 pounds. And it's not that he's that overweight. He's a solid big— I mean, he could play. He's built like a football player.

David Kaufer [00:20:25–00:20:30]

Yeah, I was gonna say, it sounds like he could be a linebacker for Michigan.

Stephen Laine [00:20:30–00:21:07]

Oh yeah. So anyways, I'm trying to get him out of there. I'm like 5'9, but I don't— I'm not near as big as Matthew. I can't physically get him out of there. So anyways, we're trying to get him out of there. He's ransacking through the entire basement just looking for DVDs and video games. I can't get over there. Then about 5 minutes later, police show up and there's probably about 2 or 3 of them. They're talking to me, seeing what methods we can use. to get him out of the basement. And I'm going to tell you, the police in my neighborhood are absolutely great. They were so understanding.

David Kaufer [00:21:07–00:21:08]

That's good to hear.

Stephen Laine [00:21:08–00:21:44]

Yes, they were great and they were really empathetic towards him. And so we did— one of the police officers said, hey, I got a Toy Story DVD up here for you. So he runs right up the basement stairs. And so he tries ransacking through another area of the house. And so it took me like 2 or 3 police officers to get down there. We get him out of the house. He's laying down on the front yard and we were able to gently restrain him. And so he's not melting down or anything. What it is that he's doing is he's staring at the officers' tattoos and totally fascinated by them.

David Kaufer [00:21:44–00:21:45]

Oh, wow. Okay.

Stephen Laine [00:21:45–00:22:15]

Yeah. So we just gently holding him until the EMTs show up. EMTs show up. They take him to the hospital. I'm in the ambulance with them. He goes in the hospital. We're waiting at the ER and I talked to a psychiatrist after waiting for about an hour and a half. They give him some meds, stabilize him. He returns home. Okay. So he's good for a week at this point. You know, he returns home, he's fine. No issues.

David Kaufer [00:22:15–00:22:17]

Kind of back in the routine. Everything's good.

Stephen Laine [00:22:18–00:22:41]

Back in the routine, everything's good. Yeah, I mean, he's, he's going to a life skills school and he's doing okay there. Nothing's wrong going on. And so I, um, so then I get a phone call from his life skills school that, uh, hey, he's trying to access, he's trying to run, he's trying to go in different areas, and he just tried going into an Amazon truck.

Announcer [00:22:41–00:22:42]

Oh, wow.

Stephen Laine [00:22:42–00:22:44]

And I'm like, oh no.

David Kaufer [00:22:44–00:22:45]

No.

Stephen Laine [00:22:45–00:23:36]

Yeah. And so, so I go over there, pick him up from his life skills school, come back home. And I'm like, you know, I'm, I'm doing my old methods of calming him down, making sure he doesn't escalate or

anything. And at this point, he seems like he's not escalating at all. Everything seems to be okay. And I'm like, you know what, I'm gonna try and go— I tell my mom, she's gonna watch him. I'm also like, I'm gonna try and go to work. I think he's fine now. You know, I think it was just You know, he doesn't seem elevated or anything. And so I go to work.

Not even 5 to 10 minutes later, I get a phone call. Matthew ran away again. And so we're looking— so I drive back home and I pull into my driveway. Here's Matthew sprinting back home carrying a bunch of DVDs.

And so—

And I want to let you know where I live. It's about 5 to 6 houses away from a very busy road.

David Kaufer [00:23:43–00:23:47]

Oh, sure. Right, right. So yeah, it's terrifying.

Stephen Laine [00:23:47–00:23:48]

It's terrifying.

David Kaufer [00:23:48–00:23:49]

Yeah.

Stephen Laine [00:23:49–00:24:36]

So anyways, I've got— I have Matthew wear this little lanyard. It says, I have autism, with his name on it and my phone number if he was ever to go missing. So I get a phone call from this guy. He says to me, are you Steven? Are you Matthew Lane's dad?

I'm like, yes, I am. Who is this? He's like, well, he just tried— he just went into my house. And he took a bunch of movies. And I'm like, oh, in order to get in, I said, where do you live?

And he lives on the other side of this very busy road. And Matthew's got— and Matthew doesn't have a — Matthew doesn't do really well crossing busy intersections. So I'm thinking to myself, he could have easily gotten hit by a car.

Stephen Laine [00:24:37–00:25:22]

So I'm like, okay, I'm gonna take the DVD. I said, so he's— my son's elevated. He's trying to run away again. And so I'm like, I'm calling into work. I'm not going into work after this.

You know, he's just too worked up. So I take him. So I— after he did calm down, I brought the DVDs back. I managed to get ahold of his psychiatrist. And so I got him into the next day to see his doctor.

I told her everything that's been going on. We do a new regimen of meds with him and see if that works. And at this point, I'm like, well, this is becoming a big issue now with him. I'm ordering AngelSense GPS on him. And so I got overnighted.

I'm like, this, we got to do this.

David Kaufer [00:25:22–00:25:25]

Yeah, yeah. You want to be able to see where he is.

Stephen Laine [00:25:25–00:26:04]

Yeah. Yep. So, um, so we ordered— I ordered that. And so Again, week goes by, he's doing okay, no issues really. And so, and I end up taking, you know, some time off of work just to observe him on his new bed to see how he was doing. And so third time I'm like, okay, well, I'm gonna— so third time that happened was, okay, I think he's all right. And so it was on Sunday, my— I was gonna go to my best friend's house on Sunday afternoon. And my best friend, he lives right around the block from me. And we've been lifelong friends. We've known each other for almost 40 years.

David Kaufer [00:26:04–00:26:06]

Oh, wow. That's great. Great.

Stephen Laine [00:26:06–00:26:31]

Yeah, we're practically like brothers. So I go over there. And then guess what happens? I look at my phone. Matthew left my house. And so I'm like, oh my God. So he's crossed. So I'm following the GPS. He's crossing this very busy road over and over again. And I'm like, oh my God, he's got to get killed. He's got to get killed.

David Kaufer [00:26:31–00:26:34]

Your heart must have been racing. I mean, it was.

Stephen Laine [00:26:34–00:27:41]

It was. I mean, multiple times he's crossing this very busy road with a speed limit of 35 miles an hour. There's traffic at all times. And I'm like, oh my God, he's just got to get himself killed. I'm going to be going to his funeral.

That's exactly what I'm thinking. And so I find him, Thankfully, I had the GPS on him. I find him in a store. And it's a store that has like video games, DVDs, toys, you know, the whole nine yards. And so he's like, he's like got a whole rack.

He's got a whole thing of them. Like, he's got like at least about \$200 worth of merchandise in his hands. I'm like, hey, Matthew, we gotta put these back. He goes, no, I'm gonna take them. I'm gonna take them.

So no, we gotta put these back. And so he's just trying to ransack through the store with me in there with him. And so I called the police. I'm like, I can't, you know, he's still elevated now. He's gonna have to go back to the ER. And so I called the police.

And I don't know what schools are like over in your area, but in our area, we're in Michigan, a lot of the schools have what we call a police resource officer.

Mm-hmm.

And so we have that here in Michigan where there's a cop on the grounds of the school. And I know him, he's really a nice guy, great guy. So anyways, guess who shows up? Matthew's resource officer that he knew from high school.

David Kaufer [00:27:57–00:27:59]

Oh, that's helpful, right?

Stephen Laine [00:27:59–00:28:15]

Yeah, it was very helpful. Yeah. I mean, I already knew the police in my department and where I live, they're really good with Matthew. And it was kind of funny because it's some of the same police officers that showed up at the last incident. They kind of knew what they were dealing with.

David Kaufer [00:28:15–00:28:21]

So yeah, yeah. I mean, that's good, right? Like, yeah, it's, it's, I mean, everyone's kind of familiar with the situation.

Stephen Laine [00:28:21–00:29:21]

Exactly. Exactly. So anyways, you know, we get them, you know, the police officers are, you know, de-escalating, you know, de-escalating the situation with them. So anyways, officers get in there, they, you know, get them into the ambulance. And so I'm waiting at the ER, and I know like, this is this This is getting really bad at this point.

And so we wait in the ER and we're just waiting. And the psychiatrist shows up and I tell him what's going on. And he says, we're probably going to have to look at inpatient psychiatric for him. And I'm like, well, okay. And in Michigan, there isn't a whole lot of psychiatric hospitals.

There really isn't. And so You're pretty much waiting until a bed opens up and you just can't just pick whichever one you want to go to. You just got to wait until there's an opening. And so I'm like, well, I'm just going to stay here at the ER with my son until there's an opening. If I got to wait here a week, I'll wait here a week.

Announcer [00:29:21–00:29:22]

Mm-hmm.

Stephen Laine [00:29:22–00:29:46]

And it did come to that. The next day, we did find him a bed at a psychiatric hospital. And so they transported him over there. And they dropped him off at nighttime and I'm coming back home and my mind's just racing. I felt like I just abandoned my son.

David Kaufer [00:29:46–00:29:47]

Right. That'd be so hard.

Stephen Laine [00:29:47–00:30:10]

It was. It was. And so I returned and so I'm like, this is just so much. I don't know what the future's going to happen. I don't know how they're going to rule this. I don't know if he's going to be returning back home or if he's going to be, you know, in some kind of residential facility. I don't know what's going on.

David Kaufer [00:30:10–00:30:11]

Right. Right.

Stephen Laine [00:30:11–00:30:13]

A million thoughts are running through my head at this point.

David Kaufer [00:30:13–00:31:00]

Well, I'm curious, Steve, what kinds of things were they telling you in terms of the psychiatric aspect, in terms of having him admitted to a psychiatric ward? Because I think that's something that You know, again, people would be interested in it. It's, it's, you know, we've talked a lot about how behaviors, quote unquote, can be misinterpreted. Impulsive behavior, you know, there's a lot of things that kids like our kids can do that tend to be kind of uniquely autistic, you know, and not necessarily a sign of something underneath it from a psychiatric standpoint.

So I'm kind of curious in terms of what the— the thinking was there.

Stephen Laine [00:31:00–00:31:15]

Well, I'm glad you brought that up because when he was at the ER at the hospital he was at, there was a lot of inaccurate information that was forwarded to the psychiatric hospital. And one of those things that they said was that he was aggressive.

David Kaufer [00:31:15–00:31:18]

Well, that's a red flag right there.

Yeah.

I mean, that kind of sets the tone for who they're dealing with.

Stephen Laine [00:31:23–00:31:42]

Well, think about it like this. All right. You know, you're in a strange environment and they're trying to do a blood draw and, you know, you've got 4 to 6 big security guys holding you down to do a blood draw. Well, any kind of—

David Kaufer [00:31:42–00:31:55]

Exactly right. Anytime you're dealing with restraint, with most— I mean, again, neurotypical people, I mean, you're going to— a lot of people are going to respond to that.

Stephen Laine [00:31:56–00:32:08]

And when we were in the ER, I mean, there was like all these people coming in there that were just up all hours of the night screaming, and it wasn't a good place for him at all.

David Kaufer [00:32:08–00:32:26]

No, no, it's— no, I mean, for, for someone, I'm sure, again, we had to talk about this, but I would imagine there's sensory issues, right? I mean, yeah, right, like sensory input he's probably very sensitive to. I mean, it's, it's kind of Yes. The worst case scenario.

Stephen Laine [00:32:26–00:33:39]

And I said, look here, that's totally inaccurate. He is not aggressive. He's not aggressive at all. He's one of the kindest people that you can meet. Because when he went to a psychiatric hospital, that's exactly what I told him.

I said, no, that is not accurate information at all. You know, and so, and when he was in a psychiatric hospital, there was a point that, you know, he was calling me every day, you know, And I said, right now, your job is to be in the hospital right now. That's one thing that does help with Matthew and his brother Aiden is like, they tell me they have jobs to do. And that helps them cope, right? Your job is to be in the hospital right now.

And then, you know, we'll go from there, Matthew. Okay. So I'm talking to him 4 or 5, you know, I'm talking to him every day for about 10, 15 minutes, you know, over the phone. That's great. And then all of a sudden, I'm not hearing from him.

So I'm upset at this point. They're not considering that he might have some abandonment issues. Again, they're not considering these things. And so I got into pretty much a shouting match with his caseworker over this because I'd say, well, why hasn't he called me in 5 days? What is going on?

No one has updated me on anything.

David Kaufer [00:33:39–00:33:44]

And so Yeah, you're totally in the dark for like—

Stephen Laine [00:33:44–00:33:47]

Yeah, I was totally in the dark about 4 or 5 days.

Stephen Laine [00:33:48–00:34:18]

Yeah. So part of that was over— I mean, I understand part of it was over the weekend. But yeah, so last I heard from him was Thursday, and then I didn't hear— so I didn't hear back from him at all. I had to call them on like that Tuesday or Wednesday and say, well, what's going on here? He hasn't called me or anything. You know, you're dealing with someone who's autistic, who's got abandonment issues. You know, he probably thinks I abandoned him and left him. You people are not seeing it like that.

David Kaufer [00:34:18–00:35:11]

Well, exactly. I was thinking about this as you're telling the story, Steve, in terms of these multiple incidents. And again, I'm, you know, I'm just a dad. I'm not an expert. But it does seem to be the common thread there, right?

Like in terms of the elopement, tended to happen when you were gone, when you're, you know, when you, you know, you were just, you weren't there for him. There's, you know, there's, there's an obvious attachment, which I'm sure is, you know, is so special on one hand, right? Like there's the bond. I have no doubt that you have, because you cannot not have it again, being in those shoes. But yeah, that's, you know, that may be, you know, one of those situations where, whether he may be going through something that just when dad's gone, that he just flipped a switch as well, it sounds like.

Stephen Laine [00:35:11–00:36:09]

Yeah. And so they kept me in the dark, you know, and then, you know, eventually it's like, kind of like when he was in the hospital, it was like, okay, we'll keep him here, stabilize him and give him back to his dad. And so that did happen. And then, you know, I got the paperwork back. And the only thing that was on his paperwork as far as follow-up is follow up with a psychiatrist.

That was it. It was like, okay, you just kept him there, gave him a new regimen of meds. And right, I don't think there was that much help in that hospital, you know. And, you know, that's really unfortunate. And I know it's not just to the hospital he was at.

I feel like that's probably a problem throughout the whole United States. You know, when it comes to hospitalization amongst those with disabilities or special needs. I know some people don't like the word disability, so I'll use special needs.

David Kaufer [00:36:09–00:36:21]

So yeah, I mean, I think people, you know, again, people know. I mean, yeah, look, a lot, a lot of times you're dealing with, they have disabilities, you know, again, it just, it's just how you define it.

Stephen Laine [00:36:21–00:36:57]

Yeah. So when he came home, I put multiple locks throughout every door in my house. Um, I stayed with them for 2 weeks. And so I took a leave of absence from my, from my employer, stayed with them, made sure everything was going smoothly. And then so I've been back to work now for about a week and a half. And there's been no attempts at elopement. And he hasn't asked for DVDs, Blu-rays, or video games. So he hasn't even asked about So far so good. So, so far so good. Yeah. So hopefully we continue on this route.

David Kaufer [00:36:57–00:37:10]

And it sounds like from your post, Steve, again, that you've been, I mean, you've been processing a lot obviously, uh, but you've also been spending a lot of time with him talking to him.

David Kaufer [00:37:12–00:37:45]

Have you been trying to talk through this, you know, in a way? Because one of the things that, um, I think you had posted again that really struck me was, you know, you're saying like healing doesn't begin the day Someone is discharged, you know, and so you've been dealing with this, the healing from the trauma of being hospitalized to being in a, you know, this foreign environment around different people, all of this. So now you're kind of dealing with this post-event trauma. How are you trying to, how are you processing that? And how are you trying to work with that with Matthew?

Stephen Laine [00:37:45–00:38:16]

Well, right now, probably the first few days were probably the hardest because All he wanted to do was sleep and sleep and sleep. And so I was really concerned at that point. He did manage to get himself out of that. And so he was, at that point, he kept on saying to me, is hospital all done? And I said, yes, Matthew, the hospital is all done. He says, no more hospital. No more hospital.

David Kaufer [00:38:19–00:38:20]

Yeah.

Stephen Laine [00:38:20–00:39:09]

Matthew will internalize a lot of his emotions, but in his own way, it will come out. Sure. Yeah. I'm just letting him kind of bring it out at his own pace, what he's feeling and all that. As far as healing, I've been just staying there for him as much as I can. Um, now his brother, he, he's actually— when Matthew went to the hospital, Aiden actually did remarkably well, better than I thought he would do. However, since Matthew's return, his anxiety has actually increased, uh, dramatically, and I feel it is due to he's afraid of another incident happening with his brother. Sure.

David Kaufer [00:39:09–00:39:11]

Yeah, because he He witnessed the—

Stephen Laine [00:39:11–00:39:22]

Because he witnessed the one incident that was across the street from my house. He witnessed his brother going into the ambulance and he thought the police were coming to take him away forever.

David Kaufer [00:39:22–00:39:30]

Right. Yeah. That's a natural fear to have in terms of— and it probably was very chaotic and—

Stephen Laine [00:39:30–00:39:43]

Oh yeah. Yeah. And I keep on telling Aiden, you know, the police are not there to take Matthew away. They were there to help. And so that's helping him process his emotions as well.

David Kaufer [00:39:43–00:40:15]

And you've said, you know, this is one of the things that resonated because I said in our own case, Stone, who's visiting again— hi, Stone— um, you know, has had to deal with his own traumatic incidents, um, and including obviously just in his case being non-speaking for nearly 16 years. And you can only imagine what that can do. But also he has epilepsy. And so he has seizures sometimes, you know, which are scary as hell, as you can imagine.

Stephen Laine [00:40:15–00:40:16]

Oh, yeah.

David Kaufer [00:40:16–00:41:00]

Um, so it was really interesting in our case, you know, coming— when he began to communicate, it opened up his world and so much. But you talked about internalizing feelings, internalizing trauma. And again, that really struck because we saw that with Stone. And so I realized how traumatized he was just in terms of how he wanted to be even closer to me. So, you know, things, holding hands, just making sure like, you know, it was like a minor elopement.

I take our dog for a walk. I told you we wake up like uber early and we go for a walk. There's a time that he had left the house. It was like at the school where I take the dog for a walk. And this was like in

the middle of winter, barefoot, you know?

Stephen Laine [00:41:00–00:41:01]

Right.

David Kaufer [00:41:02–00:41:10]

And it really struck me just how traumatized he was and just how he just kind of needed that, you know, the comfort. I think, you know, a lot of this, they're looking for comfort.

Stephen Laine [00:41:10–00:41:23]

Yeah, I totally agree with you on that. And that's something I've noticed with Matthew in his last couple of weeks is that he's gotten very much attached to me, even more so prior to his hospitalization. Yeah.

David Kaufer [00:41:24–00:41:39]

Yeah. I think that's understandable. Right. In terms of he, if he had kind of, you know, we call it abandonment issues or the concern, you know, that you're, you're his rock. Yeah.

Stephen Laine [00:41:39–00:41:40]

Yeah.

David Kaufer [00:41:40–00:41:42]

I mean, you're, you're there for him.

Stephen Laine [00:41:42–00:41:50]

Yeah. I mean, you know, he's gone through a lot of changes in his life and, you know, I think this was probably the one that hit him the hardest.

David Kaufer [00:41:50–00:41:53]

Yeah. Yeah. I'm sure. I'm sure it has.

Stephen Laine [00:41:53–00:41:54]

Yeah. Yeah.

David Kaufer [00:41:54–00:42:05]

What can you talk about? Have there been like little victories or little signs that you're seeing that the healing is happening or things that maybe other people wouldn't notice against, given how close you are?

Stephen Laine [00:42:05–00:42:16]

Um, I would say one thing is he's returning a little bit to how he was, you know, like I just took him to see the new Spider-Man movie in a crowded movie theater.

David Kaufer [00:42:17–00:42:18]

And yeah.

Stephen Laine [00:42:18–00:42:19]

Yeah. And for—

David Kaufer [00:42:19–00:42:20]

We saw that too.

Stephen Laine [00:42:20–00:42:33]

Very cool. Yeah. Yeah. So anyways, for the longest time I would have to take him into the sensory-friendly showings. And so now this was actually the first time I took him into a crowded movie theater.

David Kaufer [00:42:33–00:42:35]

That's great.

Stephen Laine [00:42:35–00:42:48]

Yeah. And so he did well, he was quiet, wasn't disturbing anybody. And for those of you who haven't seen the new Spider-Man movie, I'm not gonna give any spoilers, but it's a long movie. It's about a 2.5-hour movie.

David Kaufer [00:42:48–00:42:49]

Yeah. Oh yeah.

Yeah.

It kept going. I kept thinking like, okay, it's over now. Nope.

Nope.

It's not. There's another.

Yeah.

So he sat there for a whole 2 and a half hours and he was great. So that was, that's a recent victory that we had with him.

David Kaufer [00:43:01–00:43:12]

That's it. And that's a big one. And good, good, good on you, Steve, for taking him and not, not shying away from that kind of a challenge.

Right.

I mean, like you said, you didn't just wait the sensory-friendly opportunities are amazing. I'm so glad that we have those now. Like, again, that we've come that far as a society. But it's also nice if you don't have to wait for that or hope for that, right? Like, if you're in a situation like, hey, let's just, let's go see a movie. So that's good. I mean, I think that's really cool.

Stephen Laine [00:43:33–00:43:46]

Yeah. So we did very well with that. So that's the most recent victory we've had. The other victories I would say is we have not had any attempts of elopement. Since he was in the hospital.

David Kaufer [00:43:46–00:43:47]

That's great.

David Kaufer [00:43:49–00:43:51]

Yeah. And we hope, you know, we hope that continues.

Stephen Laine [00:43:52–00:43:53]

Yeah.

David Kaufer [00:43:53–00:44:18]

One of the things again that struck me, Steve, is you're carrying a lot. You know, like this, this again falls, falls on you. Um, how are you taking care of yourself? What are you doing? Because, you know, you, it's the, it's the analogy, it's a cliché. Yeah, it's true, right? Like the whole airplane's going down, you got to put on the oxygen mask for yourself before you can take care of your kids.

Stephen Laine [00:44:18–00:44:53]

Well, I got a couple things I do. One thing is I would like to get back into is running. I've ran since I was 9. I love to run. I've ran since I was 9 years old. I ran competitively in middle school and high school, and then I stopped, and then I went back into it. about 6 years ago. This summer, I have not been able to run because of all the things that's been going on with Matthew. That's one thing I would like to get back into once things, if they do settle down, I will be getting back into running again. The other thing that I do is—

David Kaufer [00:44:53–00:45:15]

That's huge. I want to applaud that because I think that's huge. I think the physical, again, speaking from experience, I've been a runner For much of my life. I haven't been running as much in the last year or two because of injuries and other things. But that's so healthy and just so cleansing, right? Like, it's just such a mind cleanse when you get out there.

Stephen Laine [00:45:15–00:45:46]

Yep. And so that's one thing I might want to get back into maybe once I know things are more settled. That's my goal. Yeah. The one thing that I'm doing now is, like I said, my best friend, he lives right around the block from me. So I go over there whenever He's open and I'm open. You know, I see him sometimes on Saturday evenings. You know, that helps a lot when the boys are in bed. The other thing is that I do take care of myself, which you are probably aware of, is my writing. That's very therapeutic for me.

David Kaufer [00:45:46–00:45:47]

That's great.

David Kaufer [00:45:49–00:45:56]

Yeah. You're very prolific with your writing. And again, I know, again, speaking from experience, it is. Yeah.

It's very therapeutic.

Um, yeah.

And it's all, you know, it's also kind of good. It's kind of nice to document it, right? In terms of, it gives you, gives you kind of milestones and things to look back on. But more than anything, and I see this from the comments, from, from, you know, you're educating people, right? You're, you're sharing what this, what this experience is like and helping people understand because there are still so many misunderstandings, misperceptions of what the autistic world could look like.

Stephen Laine [00:46:30–00:46:44]

Oh, definitely. And it's like this, I wrote something just recently about how some people still to this day think all autistic people are like them from the movie Rain Man.

David Kaufer [00:46:44–00:46:45]

Like Rain Man.

Stephen Laine [00:46:45–00:46:51]

Still, yeah, still to this day. I wrote a piece about it the other day. No, yesterday I wrote about it.

David Kaufer [00:46:51–00:46:52]

Yeah, I saw it. That was great.

Stephen Laine [00:46:52–00:47:01]

Last year, someone went up to me and said that. I'm like, oh, they're like Rain Man. Like, and I was not in a place where I could really express my opinion. So I had to walk away.

David Kaufer [00:47:01–00:47:03]

Right, right. Not quite.

Stephen Laine [00:47:04–00:47:05]

Yeah, not quite. Yeah.

David Kaufer [00:47:05–00:47:08]

Not quite. I mean, it's— yeah, that's—

David Kaufer [00:47:09–00:47:31]

Every— everyone's different. I mean, it's just— oh, yeah, it truly is a spectrum. And that's its own discussion too, right? People who are, who want to argue over what qualifies, what counts as autism and what doesn't. But the bottom line is just there are unique challenges that come with it, being a parent.

Stephen Laine [00:47:31–00:47:35]

Yeah.

David Kaufer [00:47:35–00:47:55]

Kind of getting back, what has this experience, what has this taught you about yourself in terms of both, you know, from kind of a big picture standpoint, Steve, Being a dad is something that— turn the clock back 20 years ago when you thought about being a dad, you probably didn't— this isn't probably what you imagined.

Stephen Laine [00:47:55–00:48:06]

No, it wasn't. And I'm going to tell you right now, um, to put it in simple, very simple terms, I'm a lot more resilient than I thought I was. A lot more.

David Kaufer [00:48:06–00:48:09]

Yeah. That's awesome. Yeah. Say hi. Hi.

Stephen Laine [00:48:09–00:48:11]

Here, have a good one. Hi, Stone.

There he is.

Nice little guy. He's great.

David Kaufer [00:48:17–00:48:19]

Yeah. He's a happy guy.

Stephen Laine [00:48:20–00:48:22]

Yeah. Yeah. He looks happy. Happy.

David Kaufer [00:48:22–00:48:36]

Happy. Resilience is everything, Steve. And you know, yeah, I think we, we all kind of can relate to that. Learning that we're stronger than we, than we thought. Yeah.

Happy, good.

Happy, good. All right, he's gonna, he's gonna disappear again. All right, well, we, we mentioned before that we like to have some fun, you know, kind of some fun segments that we want to include.

And, you know, I'm gonna, I'm gonna launch into these. Each one of these, Steve, we have, uh, we have jingles to kind of play. And so we're gonna start with Autism Tip of the Week.

Stephen Laine [00:48:59–00:49:02]

Hey parents, gather around, it's time to speak.

David Kaufer [00:49:03–00:49:42]

We're here with your tip of the week, strategies and wisdom just for you. Autism parents, we know what you go through. All right, it's time for our autism tip of the week. And, you know, I know you didn't initially come into this, uh, episode with a tip of the week, but I'm wondering if looking back now, Steve, if you, you know, kind of the experience that you had dealing with, you know, a major incident or anything like that. Is there maybe a piece of advice that you learned from this most recent episode that you want to share?

Stephen Laine [00:49:42–00:50:18]

Yeah, it's just that I think what you need to do is surround yourself with a strong support system. You know, and I'm gonna tell you, a lot of people, you know, whether it's online or in my personal life, they really came through. during these past couple months, you know, with these incidents I've had with my oldest son, Matthew. And they've came through in ways I didn't imagine that would happen. So a much — a great thank you to them. So I think that's what you ultimately need if you're an autism parent, a strong support system behind you.

David Kaufer [00:50:18–00:50:55]

You're so right. I mean, it's critical. It's absolutely critical. Um, I can't imagine, like you said, trying to do it without having some level of support system, whether it's family, family and friends in your case, it sounds like, which I'm so happy that you have. So that's a great tip.

So if you're out there, again, search for that. I mean, you can't— don't try to do this. Don't try to do this alone. It's, um, you know, no one's Superman, no one's Superwoman, you know, to be able to do it all alone. Okay, the next segment we're gonna have is called Autism Fact or Fiction.

Get QuickTime ready, and here we go.

Stephen Laine [00:50:56–00:50:57]

This is Autism Fact or Fiction.

David Kaufer [00:50:58–00:51:26]

We're breaking down what's real, what's rumor, and what might surprise you. Let's go. All right, so this is again where we like to maybe kind of throw out a stereotype in a way. Maybe we already, uh, maybe we already did that with the Rain Man analogy, but you know, or talk about maybe something, uh, you know, something that people may not know, an autism fact that maybe people may not know. But again, if you have something, otherwise that's fine if you don't.

Stephen Laine [00:51:26–00:51:36]

As far as a thing, you know, that is that all autistics don't show emotion. That is not true.

David Kaufer [00:51:36–00:51:39]

Yeah, absolutely.

Stephen Laine [00:51:39–00:51:40]

Yeah.

David Kaufer [00:51:40–00:51:46]

You want to elaborate on that a little bit in terms of— so You see that perception still out there, don't you?

Stephen Laine [00:51:46–00:52:14]

Oh, yeah. Yeah, I do see it. Yeah. And, but not as much anymore. But I used to see it back early on when my kids were first diagnosed. But it's still out there. I can tell you from my own experiences, like my kids laugh, they make jokes, you know, that they're— they show like if they're happy or if they're sad. You know, they show a whole array of emotions just like you and I do.

David Kaufer [00:52:14–00:52:59]

Yeah. Yeah. I mean, the bottom line is, right, they're human first and autistic second. I mean, that's just, it's just, it's a, just, it's a truly just a word we use to describe kind of this, you know, the way their brains are wired a little differently and how it expresses itself differently too. Um, like you say, yeah, they still have emotions.

That's, that's, that's a great one. All right, the next one. And again, this is one that this whole episode has been kind of like a parent confession. But we like to talk about things that, you know, things that we've learned that we can share with others that maybe either make us cringe a little bit, or again, maybe, you know, makes us— hindsight, we're like, God, I can't believe I did that. So we've, we've got a little jingle for that as well.

Stephen Laine [00:52:59–00:53:33]

Morning routines can go astray. Found socks in the fridge one day. Laughter's the best remedy. Hey, we're just finding our own way. Mom-Dad Confessions every week, sharing joys and moments we seek. Honest tales that make us unique.

David Kaufer [00:53:37–00:53:48]

Yeah, and it is a club, right? Like, we all— it's a parenting club, and then there's the autism parenting club. It's, you know, we all have things that we look back at, like I said, and just kind of say, what, what was I thinking?

Stephen Laine [00:53:48–00:54:22]

Yeah. Um, as far as like me, like, I could, you know, look back at things, you know, like when my kids were first diagnosed, and I didn't believe it. And it took me a year to come to her diagnosis. I didn't come to church for— it took me a full year. And so back then, I didn't even tell anybody. I didn't tell family. I didn't tell my closest friends. I didn't tell anybody. And so I didn't come out until 2012 and say, hey, my kids have autism. Even my own mother didn't know.

David Kaufer [00:54:22–00:54:24]

No kidding. Wow.

Stephen Laine [00:54:24–00:54:26]

Yeah. So I kept that as a big secret.

David Kaufer [00:54:26–00:54:28]

That's a real level of denial.

Stephen Laine [00:54:28–00:54:33]

I mean, I went into full-blown denial for a whole year and look where I'm at now compared to that.

David Kaufer [00:54:33–00:54:51]

I mean, look, 2 opposites, right? Like going from full-blown denial to full-blown advocate. And before I forget, I want people— how can people find you in terms of find your writing? Is it— do you do anything beyond your Facebook posts?

Stephen Laine [00:54:51–00:55:13]

As of right now, I'm doing just a Facebook post right now. Eventually, I'll probably do more. you know, down the road maybe hit other platforms, but the best place for right now is my Facebook, which is Steven, S-T-E-V-E-N, and then my last name, Lane, L-A-I-N-E. It's like the car lane but with the I in the middle.

David Kaufer [00:55:13–00:55:29]

With I in it. Yeah. So again, I encourage, uh, listeners to follow Steve or, you know, friend him. I don't know, Steve, how, how, uh, Like, I'm filtering, I'm unfriending people, but you always, you can always follow people on Facebook.

David Kaufer [00:55:30–00:56:21]

Yeah. See what they're posting. Okay. The last, the last quick segment we want to have, because we do want to add, you know, I like to end things on a positive note. And that's one of the things, again, I appreciate about your writing and your posts is even as you keep them as real as they are, some, again, raw in certain cases, uh, you always I think find a way to show some level of optimism, some, some kind of hope.

And I think, you know, in general, we all need hope in this world, this crazy, incredibly weird world right now, but particularly again with the complexities that autism parents face. So, um, we'll go ahead and kick off what we call the Light of the Week. Light on the Spectrum, a moment, person, or story bringing Something good.

Stephen Laine [00:56:22–00:56:34]

It feels hopeful, grounded, not performative. Use it for a person, a moment, a breakthrough, a story.

David Kaufer [00:56:34–00:56:48]

All right, so it's actually light on the spectrum. One of these weeks I'll get it right. I know my producer Dave is laughing behind the scenes. Okay, but Steve, what, uh, what's a moment over the past few months that And gave you hope?

Stephen Laine [00:56:48–00:57:29]

Well, what gave me hope is all the people that really came through for me and that's been there for me. Like I said, you see a lot of dark things right now in the times we're living in. When I see all these people come through, give me support, especially with the things that have been going on with my oldest son Matthew, it's really putting my faith back into society. And, you know, the people I surround myself with are great people. And if we could do this, you know, who knows what we could do down the road collectively as a whole within the autism community. Yeah.

David Kaufer [00:57:30–00:58:02]

Oh, that's great. And that's the perfect note to end things on. So, you know, Steve, I really do want to thank you across the board. Like I said, one of the things I really admire most is that, you know, you don't try to present a perfect picture of autism or parenting. You know, you simply share what's real, and I think that's why so many families are connecting to your writing. Your honesty helps make—helps people feel less alone. So thank you again for joining us today and everything you're doing for our community.

Stephen Laine [00:58:02–00:58:04]

Well, thanks for having me.

David Kaufer [00:58:04–00:58:12]

Yeah, it's been a real pleasure. I know we'll be, you know, we'll be in touch and communicating online. We're all in the club together.

Stephen Laine [00:58:12–00:58:13]

Yes, we are.

David Kaufer [00:58:13–00:58:42]

I mean, not something that we volunteered for, but once we're in, I think we recognize it's a very unique and special place to be in. So thank you again. And for all the listeners and viewers, thanks for joining us. Be sure to leave your reviews, comments, email me at david.coffer@hay.com. And of course, you can read more of my work at cofferinsights.com. On Substack. So until next week, we'll see you again on the lighter side of the spectrum.

Announcer [00:58:42–00:58:46]

Okay.